

Raffles Hotel & the Story of the Singapore Sling

Few places capture the colonial charm and storied past of Singapore quite like Raffles Hotel. Opened in 1887 by the Armenian Sarkies Brothers, Raffles began as a modest 10-room bungalow and quickly grew into a legendary icon of luxury in Southeast Asia. Named after Sir Stamford Raffles, the British founder of modern Singapore, the hotel became a magnet for wealthy travelers, writers, and royals.

By the early 20th century, Raffles Hotel had already achieved near-mythical status. With its tropical gardens, white verandas, and ceiling fans, it stood as a monument to colonial elegance —and to the evolving identity of Singapore itself. Notable guests have included Rudyard Kipling, Charlie Chaplin, Elizabeth Taylor, and even Queen Elizabeth II.

But Raffles is not only famous for its architecture and guests—it's also the birthplace of the Singapore Sling.

The Singapore Sling

In 1915, bartender Ngiam Tong Boon, working at the hotel's Long Bar, invented a new cocktail designed to be socially acceptable for women to drink in public. At the time, etiquette dictated that ladies should stick to tea or juice in the colonial social scene. To cleverly sidestep this, Ngiam created a pink-hued drink that looked like fruit punch but packed a punch of its own.

The original recipe blended gin, cherry brandy, lime juice, and Cointreau, among other ingredients. The result was fruity, fragrant, and deceivingly strong—a cocktail that became a symbol of early 20th-century Singapore sophistication.

Over time, the recipe evolved and was even lost for a period before being reconstructed based on old notes and memories. Today, ordering a Singapore Sling at Raffles' Long Bar remains a bucket-list experience for travelers from around the world.

RESTAURANTS RECOMMENDATIONS

By Xavier Brunelle

SONG FA (Bak Kut Teh, Bone Broth Soup)

One of Singapore's classic comfort-food experiences. Famous for its Teochew-style bak kut teh, the broth is light in color but packed with peppery punch and garlic flavor. The atmosphere is simple, busy, and very local — stainless steel tables, quick service, and the smell of simmering broth everywhere. Though you must queue for a table.

Top pick: *Pork ribs in the peppery broth, with fried dough sticks to dip into the soup. Soup is unlimited.*

JUMBO SEAFOOD

A Singapore institution for seafood lovers, especially famous with visitors and locals celebrating special occasions. Expect lively dining rooms, big round tables, and messy hands. Reservations required.

Top pick: *Chili Crab — sweet, a little spicy, rich, and best eaten with fried mantou buns to soak up the sauce.*

KENG ENG

A casual informal eatery, famous family-run Zi Char restaurant established in the 1970s, a Michelin Bib Gourmand recipient known for its wok hei dishes. Reservations required.

Top pick: *Try coffee pork ribs, signature moonlight Hor Fun, Chilli Crab and Prawn Paste fried chicken.*

SAMY'S FISH HEAD CURRY

An institution in Singapore for North and South Indian cuisine. Eat authentically on Banana Leaf and feast to your heart's desire.

Top pick: *Fish head curry and fish potato croquettes with your banana leaf set.*

KOTUWA

A Michelin Bib Gourmand awarded restaurant, led by Chef Rishi Naleendra, serving traditional Sri Lankan street food with big bold flavours and his must try signature crab curry. Reservations required.

Top pick: *Signature Crab Curry, Egg Hoppers and Mutton Roll.*

THE COCONUT CLUB

A modern restaurant dedicated to perfecting one of Singapore's simplest and most loved dishes: nasi lemak. Stylish but relaxed, with a focus on premium ingredients and traditional recipes.

Top pick: *Nasi lemak with fried chicken, sambal, peanuts, anchovies, and fragrant coconut rice.*

PEACH BLOSSOM

Want a mix of fine dining and Aesthetics? Head to Peach Blossom led by Chef Edward Chong for Marina Bayfront views and modern take on traditional Chinese flavours.

Top pick: *Steam Carrot cake with Lobster, Wok Braised Noodles with Drunken Crab and e Forbidden Roll.*

NATIONAL KITCHEN by Violet Oon

Elegant Peranakan and Singaporean fusion dining in a beautiful colonial-style setting inside the National Gallery. Refined versions of local classics with excellent presentation.

Top pick: *Dry laksa or beef rendang with sambal eggplant and traditional Kueh for dessert.*

HAWKER CENTRES

LAU PA SAT

One of Singapore's most iconic hawker centres, set inside a beautiful Victorian-style market building surrounded by skyscrapers. In the evening, the nearby street transforms into a satay market filled with smoke, grilled meat aromas, and cold beer.
Top pick: *Satay skewers with peanut sauce and fresh sugar cane juice.*

ALBERT CENTRE MARKET

A very local and less touristy hawker centre near Little India and Bugis. Great place to discover everyday Singaporean meals at very affordable prices. Busy, noisy, authentic, and full of variety.
Top pick: *Hainanese chicken rice, fishball soup noodles, laksa or ice kacang*

MARKET STREET HAWKER CENTRE

A modern two storey hawker centre in Singapore's Captia Spring Building. With 56 stalls, its popular during the week for lunch for office goers in the area. Roughly a 10min walk from the hotel.
Top pick: *Ipoh Hor Fun, Truffle Wanton Mee and Briyani.*

MAXWELL FOOD CENTRE

Probably the most famous hawker centre for first-time visitors. Easy to navigate, centrally located, and home to some of Singapore's most legendary stalls. Expect communal tables, queues, and incredible smells everywhere.
Top pick: *Tian Tian Hainanese chicken rice or Fish Noodle Soup*

CAFES AND COFFEE AND ICE CREAM

NARRATIVE COFFEE

Local Coffee Roasters serving cold brew and espresso machine style coffee

YA KUN or TOAST BOX

A Singaporean favourite for Local Coffee and Local Breakfast sets in a comfortable aircon cafe.
Try here: Kaya (Pandan and Coconut) Toast Set with Kopi of your choice

MY AWESOME CAFE

A local famous vegan cafe with vibrant and fun interior, popular for after work drinks.

APIARY ICE CREAMERY or BIRDS OF PARADISE

Local Ice Creameries featuring classic, playful and local flavours.

RESTAURANTS NEAR THE HOTEL

CHIN CHIN EATING HOUSE

Old-school Hainanese comfort food and one of the city's classic chicken rice spots.

NEW UBIN SEAFOOD

Local Singaporean seafood and "zi char" (wok fried) dishes served with a lively communal atmosphere.

UN YANG KOR DAI

Delicious and Authentic Thai affair.

ODETTE

Modern French Michelin restaurant - degustation course with optional wine paring. Reservations required.

HOLY CRAB

A more modern and playful crab restaurant with creative twists on Singaporean seafood classics. Less traditional in atmosphere, but fun, vibrant, and very indulgent. Reservations required.
Try a pepper crab or any signature crab dishes with crispy mantou on the side.

COCKTAIL AND VIEWS

NUTMEG & CLOVE

Award-winning cocktail bar inspired by Singapore's history and local flavors.

LEVEL 33

The world's highest micro brewery offering amazing views of Marina Bay Sands.

CAFFE FERNET

Italian restaurant and bar with views of Marina Bay Sands.

ROOFTOP BAR AT HERITAGE

Casual rooftop bar with views of Boat Quay and Marina Bay Sands

NIGHT HAWK

Speakeasy bar with creative menus and delicious cocktails.

JIGGER AND PONY

One of Asia's top cocktail bars, famous for classic cocktails executed perfectly.

BAR KAP

A TeoChew inspired cocktail bar inside of a traditional style 140 year old TeoChew Mansion. Where history, elegance and innovation meet.